

Red

(Spectra Book 1)

Prologue (A few weeks earlier):

Click... click... click..... click...

A girl can only refresh her emails so many times before her hand cramps. Nor could they handle this much anticipation without getting a horrible migraine.

Nevertheless, Ayla continued begrudgingly checking her inbox over and over, in the hope that maybe one of these times, she'd see the very thing she'd been waiting for. The website had said they'd send their responses hours ago; had they forgotten her?

'*Wouldn't be very hard to do.*' She couldn't help but think, holding off on her clicking for a moment to swap one sore finger out for another as if they were tag-team boxers. Her eyelids drooped so low she could barely see the screen anymore, a sudden chime from her laptop yanked her back to reality. There was something new.

"Dear Miss Walker," Way too formal to be anything else. It *had* to be it. Peeking out between the gaps in her fingers, she nervously scrolled down.

"It is our pleasure to offer you a place in this year's course, commencing next month!" This couldn't be real. Ayla had been expecting a response, obviously, but she'd actually been *accepted* into her *dream university*? It had to be a joke, a trick, a mistake? But no. For once, she hadn't imagined it; she'd really made it.

Chapter 1 (05/09/2016):

Over the years, Ayla had come to consider herself a master of telling the difference between nerves and excitement. She was the type of person to worry about every little thing around her - one quirk that moving to university didn't exactly do wonders for. It wasn't very far away, nor was it anywhere anyone had heard of, but it was still so big of a change that it had her trembling with anxiety. Or was this something new and exciting to look forward to? For once, she had no idea.

Despite her worriedness, Ayla prided herself on her strong sense of independence, so much so that she insisted on moving in all by herself, against her parents' pleas to do more than just drive her. Now here she was in a shabby-looking corridor, luggage by her feet, and a shaky hand on the doorknob. Just one turn of her wrist away from the rest of her life.

"You going in?" Another girl leant against the wall a few metres down the hallway, having been there for who knows how long.

"I- uhh..." Ayla couldn't get a word out.

"It's Ayla Walker, right?" She looked slightly older, but clearly no more than her very early twenties, "Sorry, I sound like such a stalker, don't I? I've been asking

around since Saturday to find out who my roommate is.”

So this mystery girl was who Ayla would be living with? She seemed approachable, a little too friendly maybe, but nothing she couldn’t handle. Maybe everything was going to work out just fine after all.

“It’s nice to meet you.” Ayla smiled, “I’m- oh, right.” The two exchanged a laugh, despite the awkward air.

“I’m Isabel. That’s B-E-L, not B-E-L-L-E. Sorry, *everyone* gets it wrong and I hate it.” Isabel was quite slender for such an average height, with smooth, light-but-not-pale skin, and hazel eyes that matched the loose braid strung over her shoulder. The girl wore a simple grey hoodie with a white logo on the front, along with some light-wash jeans that had naturally ripped at the knees, though it looked like an intentional choice either way. She sported a single dangling piercing on each earlobe, a delicate obsidian-coloured pendant hanging from a silver chain necklace, but what Ayla found herself drawn to in particular, was the look on her face, warm enough to put even her at ease.

Extending a hand out to Isabel (the one which wasn’t still tightly gripping the door handle) as if for a handshake, Ayla realised how stupid that was, and yanked it back. Unfortunately, Isabel had actually gone to shake it, instead left awkwardly hanging.

“Oh, umm... sorry. I thought you- I-” She stammered.

“Hey, don’t worry about it.” Isabel laughed it off. Like *she’d* ever *worry*. The girls fell silent, the odd atmosphere bringing the conversation to a screeching halt - for about a minute, at least.

“Wanna bring all that in?” Isabel asked, motioning to Ayla’s many suitcases.

“If you wouldn’t mind... I’d like that.” She replied, finally actually opening the door to her bedroom, and picking back up a duffel bag from behind her. Isabel scooped up as much as she could carry, heaving it all across the floor, yet still taking care to gently set it down on Ayla’s blank mattress. Before long, the hallway was clear, and the two had begun to actually decorate her side of their currently very bland slice of home.

“So, Ayla, where’re you from?” Isabel asked, pinning some polaroids to a corkboard.

“...Connecticut.” She replied quite sheepishly, assuming Isabel had been expecting somewhere with a little more... anything.*

“Ooooh, I’ve never been there!” She exclaimed without looking over - obviously faking her intrigue. Ayla was disheartened to have her assumption confirmed, but she appreciated the effort nonetheless. “I’m from a little

town in France, not one you'd have ever heard of." Ayla glanced over at her desk, catching Isabel's face in a reflection - downcast, maybe even mournful.

"What's it like there?" She dared to ask. Maybe some nostalgia might lift her mood?

"It's... rural. I didn't grow up with a phone, or fancy cars, or anything like that. But I managed just fine, I guess."

Ayla wanted to keep talking, to ask her so much more about her life before coming here, but the two were interrupted by Isabel's phone, buzzing in her pocket.

"Sorry, it's my brother, I've gotta take this." She smiled, and quickly scurried out of the room, leaving Ayla to finish up alone. Quickly coming down from the adrenaline of actually meeting her first university friend, and her head once again swirling with worries, she hurried to the mirror to make sure she'd looked alright for her first impression.

Brushing a lock of dark, wavy hair from her light-umber face, Ayla inspected herself up, down, left, and right to make sure she hadn't magically broken out in the last five minutes, or unknowingly had something in her nose, though she figured that even if there had been anything, there wasn't a thing she could do about it now. Rubbing her eyes, she took the chance to really

take a look at herself. Not in a critical sense, though she did have an itch in the back of her mind to keep nitpicking, but really just to have a moment to take it all in. Isabel seemed nice enough, she thought; nice enough to live with for now, and all other signs seemed to point towards the start of something great. In the end, only time would tell.

In fact, weeks passed, and as Ayla settled into life away from home, both girls quickly settled into each other's company.

"Hey, wait!" Isabel sprinted as fast as her legs would let her, desperately trying to string a backpack strap over the wrong shoulder. She finally caught up to Ayla, who had very politely asked the bus driver to hold the doors open just a little longer.

Two weeks after they'd first met, Isabel and Ayla had become inseparable. They ate, drank, studied, and did absolutely everything together. Today was no different, as the bus pulled away from its stop with a slow lurch forwards, and Isabel took a less-than-comfortable seat by her friend

"I'd rather shoot myself than do one more Wednesday again." Ayla mumbled, just loud enough for Isabel to make it out. She chuckled, giving a sarcastic pat on the back to her drained friend.

“We thinking pizzas when we get home?” She asked.

“Only from the freezer. I’m too broke to order right now.”

Their route home, as busy as it was, had a few pretty views after they passed through the city centre, with its monotonous concrete walls on every side, and began to reach the parks and quieter roads. Before long, they were filtering through the same stores, signs, and streets that let the girls know they weren’t far from home. The sun was minutes from going down, and as rows of warm street lamps flickered on, losing the last few golden rays of the sunset, something else caught Ayla’s eye. She sat up, pressing herself against the window for a better view, to Isabel’s alarm.

“Hey, you good?” She asked, putting a hand on her tense shoulder. Ayla didn’t say a word, as if any reply could break her delicate train of thought, and slowly nodded. She reached out, pressed the ‘Stop’ button next to her, and gathered up her things to get off the bus at the next chance she got.

“Ayla, ours isn’t for like fifteen minutes.” Isabel’s concern only grew, as her entranced best friend beckoned her to follow, already heading for the front of the decelerating bus*. When it came to a halt, she flew out of the doors, Isabel now in tow, quickly closing in on a narrow alley just a few doors down from the stop. A

million thoughts flooded Isabel's mind, each increasingly worse than the last, but it all came to a halt as Ayla did, having reached the start of the passage. She finally looked back over, gesturing down the alleyway with her head. Isabel shot back a clueless visage, until she noticed the warm light emanating from whatever had grabbed Ayla's attention in the first place.

"I don't know what it is... but..." She trailed off, taking a few slow steps further in. Isabel, starting to worry again, caught up to her, finally getting to see what they'd discovered.

Floating a metre and a half above the floor was a small ball of red flames. It lit up the bricks on either side with a pulsating glow, small tongues of fire flickering upwards every couple of seconds, and something about it, something extra unnatural, had Ayla completely transfixed. She took a few steps closer, and raised her hand to reach out for it.

Isabel's eyes widened in surprise. "Ayla, what are you doing?"

"I... can feel it calling me closer." She spoke without breaking her gaze on the orb.

"What if it kills you?" That might've been a bit too harsh.

“I can feel it. It doesn’t want to.”

“And if that’s just what it wants you to think? Don’t get yourself killed because a magic... *thing*... said you’d be fine!”

Ayla didn’t reply to that. She knew that neither of them were going to change their minds, and she knew that if there was ever a time to trust her gut, it was right now. Taking another step towards it, the light’s rhythmic pulsing sped up, now in time with the rapid thumping of her heartbeat. The ends of the individual flames started to lean towards her approaching hand, as Isabel began to hurry into the alley and prevent her best friend’s rapidly-nearing demise. The tongues stretched further and further as she came closer, until the tip of her index finger finally made contact, and the entire ball of energy erupted in a powerful blast.

“Ayla!” Isabel cried out, being flung backwards into a solid brick wall, and instantly losing consciousness. The last thing she saw, to her horror, was her best friend being consumed by flames.

**Author’s Note: No offence to any Connecticutians, I have never been*

**Author’s Note 2: They were sat in the front row, that’s why Ayla could get up without having to climb over Isabel*

Chapter 2 (21/09/2016, 22:12):

Seconds stretched to minutes, and minutes to hours, until Ayla finally came to. Wearily, she propped herself up on her elbows, before attempting to drag herself across the cold concrete floor towards Isabel.

“...you okay?” She groaned, trying to wake her up with a gentle shake. After a few more violent efforts, she bolted upright in the same panic as before, only calming down after a second or two of painful scrambling to her feet.

“Are *you* okay?!” Isabel asked, now the one to crouch back down and grab Ayla by *her* shoulders. “Your clothes are completely scorched! It’s a miracle they’re still in one piece.”

Ayla didn’t know what to say, glancing down at her burnt hoodie as if she’d never felt the heat in the first place. Though then again, had she?

“And your eyes...” Isabel’s expression changed, “...they’re-”

She didn’t finish her sentence, interrupted by a clumsy shuffling of feet at the end of the alley. Both girls whipped their heads around to face the frail figure a few metres away, dressed in ripped, stained clothing with a disheveled look about him.

“Hey.” He didn’t shout it, but he didn’t need to; his hoarse tone was loud enough to completely petrify the two, now slowly pulling their aching bodies up and backing against the wall.

“...Hi...” Isabel replied calmly. She didn’t make any sudden movements, not wanting to take any chances and come across as threatening, though putting on a friendly face proved difficult when every breath felt like ripping out a lung.

“What are you doing in here?” He demanded, taking a few steps further in. “This is *my* alley, y’hear?” His body looked weak, like even the girls who’d been hit by an explosion four hours ago could take him on. At least, that was until he pulled out a knife.

“Oh shit.” Ayla muttered under her breath. Unfortunately for her, it didn’t come out as quiet as she intended, and the ragged man stumbled even closer.

“What d’you say to me?” He hadn’t heard a word she’d said, but as intoxicated and paranoid as he was, he’d have taken a compliment like a death threat.

“N-nothing, sir. We were just leaving, that’s all.” Isabel kept her cool like before, though from the way she fiddled with her necklace all the while, Ayla could tell she was getting stressed.

“I know what you are. Actin’ all... innocent.” His words were slurred, but the malice wasn’t lost on them.
“You’re *thieves*!”

With that, he lurched forwards with a surprising amount of power, and pulled Isabel, the closer of the two, into a headlock. He brought the dirty knife up to her neck, near enough that with every shudder of his arm, she could feel the cold metal brush against her. Ayla froze. If she made any move, not that she even knew what to do, that lunatic wouldn’t hesitate to kill her best friend on the spot.

“Y-you don’t have to do that. Please...” It was a desperate start, but anywhere from here was progress enough.

“Uh huhh? Why’s that?” He taunted.

“I- you-” Nothing persuasive enough came to mind. Was this it? She’d failed to convince him, and just like that, they were done for? Just two slashes from that rusted, jagged bread knife would do the job. Was it even rust, or something worse? It didn’t exactly shine like it was.

Wait. Something looked... off.

The metal, or whatever of it was clean enough to shine, reflected an off-white light onto the wall, as if a

streetlamp had magically manifested behind her. Perplexed, Ayla looked from side to side to find whatever source was bouncing off the blade, but found nothing. What's more, the two across from her had begun to stare at her, bewildered.

"Ayla, are you doing that?" Isabel asked, her voice shaky. She felt the man's hold on her neck loosen, his gaze fixated on the other girl.

"Doing what?" She looked down at her hands, and noticed how illuminated they looked. In fact, so was the floor. And the walls. And the other two. "Why is everything... so..."

"It's your eyes, Ayla. They're glowing!"

Ayla put her hands up to her eyelids. Beneath them, her eyeballs themselves were red hot, but it didn't even hurt. It was unbelievable.

"What the fuck?..." The man loosened his grip on Isabel even more, terrified by what he saw in front of him.

"You a fuckin... witch?"

Isabel took her chance and uppercutted his wrist, sending the knife flying out of his hand and letting her slip away in one quick manoeuvre. In a fit of rage, he burst forward, and sprinted straight at a

caught-off-guard Ayla, who just about had time to throw one punch.

And what a punch it was. Making contact with her target's jaw, she felt the bone crunch as he was sent spinning into the brick wall.

"What the hell?" Ayla stared down at her unmarred hand, which was ever so slightly glowing as her adrenaline pumped.

"He's unconscious." Isabel grabbed her other hand, and locked eyes with her. "I know he's hurt, but we need to get out of here, *right now*."

Ayla nodded, in shock, and let herself be dragged back home to safety. The two girls, hungry and exhausted, barely managed to make it into bed before they passed out. After one uncomfortable night's sleep, the thought of getting up at their usual six-thirty alarm seemed inconceivable. Isabel yawned, still aching, as she slid herself upright and tucked her knees below her chin, while Ayla, to her own surprise, felt better than ever. Just less than twelve hours ago, she'd quite literally taken the brunt of an *explosion*, with seemingly zero adverse effects the day after.

"You okay?" Isabel took notice of her friend's odd demeanor.

“Yeah... just, thought I’d feel a bit worse. Y’know, after exploding in an alleyway and all.” She rubbed her eyes, trying to wake herself up. “Did that all really happen last night?”

“What, you touching a magic red fireball and punching a homeless man? That happened.”

Yikes. When she put it like that, maybe Ayla *shouldn’t* have trusted her gut as much. But, nothing to do about it now.

“I’m taking a day off. To... like... figure everything out.” She announced. Isabel, unsurprisingly, agreed completely, even electing to do the same. But there was still plenty of work to do.

Within half an hour, the girls found themselves sat on opposite ends of the kitchen table, staring at each other.

“Your eyes,” Isabel finally got to finish her sentence from before, “They’re bright red, you know.”

“Huh?!” Ayla stood up and rushed to the nearest mirror, taking in the sight of her own reflection. She’d seen red eyes before, but never this unnaturally vivid. It was uncanny.

“Now that you mention it, everything *has* looked off since then.” Ayla told her, taking in a view of the room.

Nothing looked wildly different, but something just wasn't right.

“Are you... taller?”

“I- ” Ayla looked down at her feet. Was that what she was noticing? Had her whole perspective shifted up a few inches just like that? Isabel gave her a look up and down.

“No, you're definitely taller. Do you feel any stronger? Weaker?” With this, Isabel began furiously typing on her laptop, glancing back over every few seconds.

Ayla strolled over to the counter, and picked up the toaster. It felt... lighter, maybe? That might not've been the most useful test of strength.

“Try the chair, that's something you've carried before. You can compare the weight.” Isabel suggested. She strolled back over to the table, slipped her palm underneath the seat, and lifted the plastic chair into the air. It'd never been particularly heavy before, but now she barely felt anything at all!

“This is incredible!” She almost shouted, rushing to try and pick up every heavy thing in sight. Even Isabel wasn't safe from being raised to the ceiling.

“How about the glowing?” She asked, being brought back to the ground. That was the most interesting part

of this new awakening, and she'd completely forgotten about it until now.

"I have no idea." Ayla replied. "I didn't exactly do it on purpose last time. But my fist started to glow a little after that punch."

"Maybe we need to get your blood pumping for some results?" Isabel suddenly slammed her laptop shut and stood up from the table. "Stay here for a few hours. I might've had a genius idea."

Chapter 3 (22/09/2016, 11:08):

“Alright, alright, I promise my eyes are covered.” Ayla stumbled up the steps, blindly guided by Isabel through a set of double doors, into...

“An old warehouse?” She asked, unimpressed. Sparse rays of sunlight slipped between gaps in the boarded windows, illuminating the dusty air as it settled on a cold, concrete floor.

“You’re not meant to look yet!”

“Sorry!” Ayla winced, scrunching her eyes shut. “I’ll forget I saw a thing, okay?”

Isabel shot her a disappointed look, then pulled her around the corner to see what she’d *actually* been wanting to show off. Set up in the corner of the enormous empty room sat a treadmill, a bench press, a punching bag, the list went on. Practically an entire personal gym, each machine had been hooked up with long, black wires to Isabel’s laptop, which sat atop its own wooden desk.

“Where did you get all these?” Ayla asked, strolling over to take a closer look at the machinery.

“I made a few calls.” She’d sported the same smirk for the last few hours. “My brother lives out of town, and he’s rich. Like, *rich* rich.”

“And he’s happy to spend his fortune on... a creaky old shack and a home gym.” Ayla took off her hoodie, and stepped onto the treadmill. Dangling from one side-rail were a few wire electrodes, the type she’d seen people wear on their temples in sci-fi movie brain scans. Of course, she eagerly stuck them on, surprised by how easily they suctioned to her forehead. Isabel, now sitting at her desk, motioned for her to switch the treadmill and get running, so they could really get started. Ayla glanced down at her hands, gently clenching them for a moment with a deep inhale, before flicking the switch on the back, and hopping onto the belt.

The next four hours or so, as some nosey passerby might’ve interpreted, were almost like some sci-fi-karate movie montage. The girls trialled their way through every single machine at their disposal, but while Ayla only grew more and more exhausted, it didn’t seem like they were getting anywhere. It wasn’t until the duo were close to giving up when Isabel finally noticed something.

“Ayla, your hands! Look at them!” She exclaimed, bolting up out of her seat. Ayla stopped mid-swing at a punching bag, and glanced down at her fists. It was no

mistake, that same warm glow had finally made its return, emanating from the very centre of her palms and faintly pulsing along with her heartbeat.

“Woah. It doesn’t hurt or anything, but I can feel it... buzzing?”

“That’s good! Try and keep a hold of the feeling, then maybe you can bring it back on command.”

Ayla squeezed her eyelids shut, and clenched her fists even tighter, focusing as much as she could on that pins-and-needles-like sensation, letting it grow even stronger, and finally letting it flow out of her hands into the room. When she cautiously took a look in front of her, the sight she was greeted with was incredible. Both of her hands shone blindingly bright, the glow stretching up her arms and even shining through the fabric of her sleeves.

“Can you focus it?” Isabel wondered.

Ayla put her hands together, clasping them into a single finger gun, figuring that would be the easiest way to visualise where to direct her power. After a few seconds, the light responded, retreating from up near her shoulders to now completely reside in her fingertips, which shot out a thin torch beam onto the wall.

“This is crazy...” She couldn’t help but mumble, as she let her hands fall apart again, and the light switched off. Though now, since she was familiar enough with the feeling, it only took a moment or two of fumbling around to switch on a new beam, streaming out of her palm.

“Can you change the colour?” Isabel was already back at her laptop, excited for some more experimentation. Ayla paused, and shut her eyes again, letting the warm light grow redder and redder until it was a solid beam of crimson.

“I wonder if I can...” Ayla trailed off, focusing on the light again as half of the red circle on the wall turned a neon green. The circle turned to a square, then a triangle, then a doughnut. She pulled her phone out, flicked through her photos until she found one simple enough, and... there it was, on the wall.

“Woah!” Isabel cautiously crept over and stood next to the beam. She waved her arm through it, which cast a shadow on the image, as if her friend were a human projector. But when Ayla rolled her eyes, and tried moving the image out of the way, it completely removed her black silhouette instead, despite Isabel still blocking the beam. With raised eyebrows, she told her to drop the beam, and when she did, the image remained plastered on the wall.

“This is so much more than just glowing hands, Ayla...” Isabel told her, astounded.

Ayla motioned with her arms, and pulled the image off of the wall like a hologram. It passed straight through the two of them without an issue as she slowly twirled it around in midair. The photo, of Isabel’s shadow posing on a blank wall, gained the shadow of a top hat and large pointed ears, before Ayla let it all vanish completely. Too stunned to speak, they both stared at each other, grinning.

“I think we can have some serious fun with this.” Ayla said.

The the next two weeks, without a doubt, completely overshadowed the girls’ time at university so far, in terms of pure excitement. Every single night, they trekked down to that same warehouse, determined to throw whatever wild ideas they could conjure up at Ayla, who in turn, really got to know the ins and outs of what she could do. After a while, she’d begun to master her control over each ray of light at her disposal - bending and reshaping them to see around corners, zoom in on a target, or even see through walls with enough focus. On top of that, her illusions slowly grew in fidelity, letting their once-shabby workspace gradually transform, even if only visually, into a grand ballroom, adorned with golden trims and chandeliers.

“How have we run out of ideas after just a couple of weeks?” Isabel joked, packing up her things after a particularly long session.

“I guess that means we’ll *have* to skip any training on my birthday tomorrow.” Ayla added, though it was half serious; if Isabel tried to drag her away, she’d flat-out refuse.

“Fine, fine, take the day off.” She rolled her eyes. “But there’s no way we’re slowing down now.”

It had barely skimmed her mind until now, but Ayla couldn’t seem to understand why Isabel had taken on such a leader-like role throughout their training. Was it something she needed to keep herself on equal ground? Did she actually feel weak in comparison to her? Of course not, that was nothing like how Isabel came across. If anything, it fit her character most for her to just enjoy bossing her friend around. But still, she’d rather know.

“Isabel,” Ayla put a hand on her shoulder, stopping the two before they headed inside their dorm building, “Why are you so eager to do all this with me?”

Isabel went silent for a minute, holding the doorhandle still. Then she sighed, looking away.

“If I’m being entirely honest...” She admitted, “I still wish you never went down that alley.”

“What?” She replied, taken aback. “But what about all of this? You’ve been so... involved, so happy to help and take charge...”

“Because that information we’ve got from it all, and the good it can do - it’s invaluable.”

“But?”

“But I can’t help but feel like there’s something else to it.” Isabel continued. “I’m worried it’s gonna get dangerous, to have those powers. And... I really don’t want you to get hurt just because I couldn’t stop you.”

Ayla nodded, unsure what else to say, really. Overall, she was just happy to have someone looking out for her.

“Isabel...” She finally replied. “Thank you.”

Chapter 4 (07/10/2016, 08:00):

“Happy Birthday Ayla!!” Isabel burst into their room, a huddle of extra dormmates flowing in the door right behind her.

She carried a ‘Breakfast Cake’, as she called it, though it was just a regular cake which they were going to eat at eight in the morning. It looked gorgeous for a homemade cake, with the number nineteen spelled out in white chips on top of the chocolate sponge. From the look of it, Isabel had spent hours the day before secretly baking it, after they’d gotten home.

“Isa, you shouldn’t have!” Ayla shuffled upright in bed, taken a little off guard by the small crowd forming at her bedside. They sang her Happy Birthday, and she blew out all nineteen of her candles.

“What did you wish for?” Someone asked. It was Stephanie, the girl one room over, who in all honesty, she didn’t really know that well.

“If I tell you, it won’t come true.” She gave an awkward smile. Truth be told, all Ayla really wanted was to go back to sleep.

Stephanie laughed, swivelling back around and heading out the door. They’d all only been in there for a few minutes, but it *was* eight o’clock on a weekday, after all.

Thankfully, it wasn't long before everyone else trickled out of the room, leaving Isabel and Ayla alone after what felt like an age.

"Looks like your wish came true." Isabel laughed, as if she'd read her mind, and threw herself down onto her own bed. "I'd do anything to stay home today."

"Why don't you?" Ayla asked her.

"I need to grab a few things after my lecture, that's all." She refused to make eye contact.

"Are you throwing me a surprise party?" Ayla asked in such a deadpan tone that made it only very debatably a question.

"Whaaat?" She fake gasped, "I'd *never*!" With that, she sprang back up, scurrying about the room as she got ready for the day.

"Hey, I'm going out shopping later, just so you know. In case I'm out when you wanna do your 'surprise'" She held up air quotes for that last word.

"Keep me updated, got it?"

She nodded, watching Isabel throw her bag over her shoulder and saunter out to catch the bus. Feeling pretty deserving of her birthday lie-in, she dropped

back onto her pillow, and within just a few minutes, she was fast asleep, dreaming away.

Ayla was no stranger to unusual dreams, nor even lucid ones, but as her sleep grew deeper, and her visions more vivid, something began to feel... off. A wave of awareness washed over her, as if she'd woken up, just in time to watch the world around her fade out into darkness. She floated in the vacuum, searching in all directions for something, anything, but to no avail. Until the girl appeared.

The figure stood far in the distance, barely even facing in Ayla's direction. Something about her, or something about where they were, made it particularly hard to make out what she actually looked like, but the colours were distinct enough to note. A shin-length white dress, with splashes of green and red all over, that contrasted with her dark skin tone and made her stand out all the more obviously. In the few seconds since she'd first appeared, a faint pink light had started emanating from somewhere even further beyond, gradually growing stronger until, when Ayla put the girl in the centre of her vision, the glow reached far past the edges of her peripherals. Ayla called out, though she couldn't hear her own voice. But the girl could.

She didn't see where the call had come from, but she began to look around, scanning. Whether it was the girl's will or her own, the two began to slowly grow ever

closer, until Ayla could manage to make out one side of a conversation.

‘No idea, yet.’ ‘I can try, if you want.’ ‘That’s too much for me.’ It made no sense without hearing the other end, but maybe she could make do if she heard enough to piece things together.

‘You’d think when there’s two of them in the same city I’d find one twice as fast.’

What? Two of what? Ayla and someone else?

‘We’ve left the first one for two weeks, and now they’re both so close. If we don’t step in today, one might slip off somewhere, and we’re back to square one.’

Now, Ayla was getting close enough to the other girl that she could nearly reach out and touch her. She tried to speak again, but no sound came out. But from what she could see from behind, *her* jaw hadn’t budged in the slightest so far. If this was really still a dream, maybe all she needed to do was mentally project whatever she was trying to say, and it would get across.

‘...hello?’ It actually worked? Ayla found herself shocked by her genius, as even the girl jolted in place, spinning around to face her. Surprised for a second, a smile spread across her face.

'There you are.' The two girls made eye contact, for just a second, and Ayla felt her mind go blank. It felt as if someone had opened a hatch in the back of her brain, and now everything had begun to pour out like a viscous waterfall. The psychic dropped her smile, concentrating, as the pink glow wavered in intensity, and the world grew fuzzy. Ayla felt a presence right inside her head, like a hand reaching in, feeling around for something. The sensation was... uncomfortable to say the least, but it only lasted a second or two. Then she held both hands up to the sky, taking in a last up-and-down of the still very bewildered dreamer before her, before swiping them downwards in an elegant motion, and disappearing entirely.

Ayla bolted upright, disoriented. It had only been about three hours since she fell asleep, but tired as she was, she wasn't about to waste the day in bed. Dressing herself in a daze, the dream refused to leave her mind. That sensation, the feeling of having something in her mind that wasn't supposed to be able to get in, it left a sour taste in her mouth that lingered for far longer than anything *really* made up would've.

Better to ignore it, surely. It was just the product of too much training, after all. Nothing to worry herself with, though she'd make sure to mention it to Isabel later tonight, just in case it did end up being something... more.

It wasn't until almost one o'clock that she finally made it out of the building, hurrying down the street to *just* catch the bus before it left her behind. With so many places to get to, sleeping in so late meant having to pick up the pace a little to get everything done on time. After all, she had a party to get to later tonight. Now that she thought about it, when *was* this party? Was it in her dorm? As far as she could think of, neither Isabel nor Ayla even *knew* enough people to fill a whole party. So what strangers did Isabel invite to pad out the guest list?

Only way to find out was to bite the bullet, it seemed. So Ayla begrudgingly made her way home, lugging two shopping bags up the hill. Setting one down at last, she fumbled around in her pockets to find her keys, and slipped the right one into the door. She was about to turn it in its lock, relieved to be done for the day, when she froze. Her eyes wandered, drifting slowly from the keyhole to the glazing... to its reflection... and to the person floating about a hundred metres in the sky behind her.